



CONTAINMENT

AUTHORITY VS. RUIN

SECURE // CONTAIN //
PRESERVE

RELEASE // EXPLOIT //
TRANSCEND

COMPREHENSIVE RULES



01 ORIENTATION

WHAT IS CONTAINMENT

A two-deck head-to-head card game about a shared crisis neither player can fully control. **Authority** builds infrastructure, studies what it captures, and tries to keep the lid on. **Ruin** wants the lid off.

Authority wants to build infrastructure, Suppress threats, convert dangerous Anomalies into Contained value, and prevent the shared Breach Track from reaching catastrophe. Ruin wants to make containment unreliable, sacrifice expendable Personnel, raise Breach deliberately, and Release the very Anomalies Authority worked to secure.

Both sides share one Breach Track. Every escalation is a resource both players are spending from the same account — which is what makes the game a fight over a shared clock, not two separate solitaire piles.

AUTHORITY

Control / midrange. Wins by stabilizing the board and out-lasting Ruin's escalation.

RUIN

Aggressive risk/release. Wins by pushing Breach into windows only it can exploit.

AT A GLANCE

2 players • 60-card starter decks (15-card competitive side deck) • 20 starting Stability • 7-card opening hand, 7-card max hand size • shared Breach Track, 0-10

If you've played Magic: the Gathering, most of the scaffolding here will feel familiar — Stability is your life total, Energy is your mana, Facilities are your lands, Personnel and Anomalies are your creatures. The Breach Track, Suppression, and Containment are new systems layered on top of that scaffolding, and they're what actually makes Containment its own game.



02 GOLDEN RULES

GOLDEN RULES & OBJECTIVE

- 1

A card's printed text always wins.

If anything in this rulebook conflicts with the exact wording on a card, the card is right and this book is wrong. This book exists to cover what cards don't spell out, not to override what they do.
- 2

“You” means that card's controller.

On any card, “you” and “your” refer to whoever controls that card at the time — not necessarily whoever owns it (a Contained or Released Anomaly can change controller over the course of a game).
- 3

Effects happen in the order they're written.

Read a card's rules text left to right, top to bottom, resolving each instruction before moving to the next.
- 4

You can't do the impossible.

If a cost or instruction can't be fully paid or performed (not enough Energy, no legal target, no Facility with open Capacity), that action simply can't be taken — nothing happens instead.

OBJECTIVE

You lose the game immediately if your Stability is reduced to 0 or lower, or if you're required to draw a card while your deck is empty. You win when your opponent loses. There is no other win condition — Containment is not a race to a separate finish line, it's a fight over how long you can keep standing.



03 ZONES & RESOURCES

WHERE EVERYTHING LIVES

ZONE	WHAT'S THERE
Deck	Your shuffled 60 cards. Face-down, unseen by either player except by card effect.
Hand	Cards you've drawn but not yet played. Hidden from your opponent. Maximum 7 at your End Phase.
Battlefield	The shared play area. Personnel, Anomalies, Facilities, and Equipment you control sit here, face up, visible to both players.
Contained	A sub-zone at a specific Containment Facility. Anomalies moved here by a Contain effect leave the battlefield as active threats but stay in play, under their containing player's control, counting against that Facility's Capacity.
Discard Pile	Face-up. Destroyed or sacrificed cards, and Protocols/Responses after they resolve, go here. Public Information either player can look through.
Breach Track	Shared — neither player owns it. A single counter from 0 to 10 tracking the crisis both decks are pushing on.

Three numbers you're always tracking:

STABILITY

Your life total. Starts at 20. No hard cap — Stabilize effects can push it above 20 unless a card says otherwise. Hits 0 or below, you lose.

ENERGY

Generated by Exhausting Facilities. Some is typed (Authority, Analysis, Ruin) — only spend typed Energy on costs that accept that type or generic costs. Unspent Energy empties at your End Phase; it does not carry into your next turn.

RESEARCH

A persistent resource. Unlike Energy, it never empties on its own — it only goes down when a card spends it.

Card types, at sorcery or response speed:

TYPE	BEHAVIOR
Personnel / Anomaly	Stays on the battlefield. Has Power/Durability, can attack and block.
Facility	Stays on the battlefield. Generates Energy when Exhausted. At most one deployed per turn.
Equipment	Stays on the battlefield, attached to one Personnel you control (never an Anomaly — every printed Equipment specifically says "Assigned Personnel"). If that Personnel leaves play, the Equipment stays on the battlefield unattached until you pay its cost again to reassign it.
Protocol / Directive	Protocols resolve once and go to the discard pile, like a sorcery. Directives stay in play as an ongoing effect once resolved, like an enchantment.
Response	Resolves once and goes to the discard pile — but can be played almost any time, including during combat or your opponent's turn, not just your Main phase.



04 SETUP

BEFORE THE FIRST TURN

#	STEP
1	Each player shuffles their 60-card deck.
2	Set both players' Stability to 20.
3	Set the shared Breach Track to 0.
4	Each player draws a 7-card opening hand.
5	Decide who takes the first turn (die roll, coin flip, whatever you like).

DECKBUILDING REMINDER

60+ cards per deck. Maximum 4 copies of any card with the same name, except Basic Facilities, which are unlimited. A 15-card competitive side deck is used for game two and three of a match, swapped in between games exactly like a sideboard.



05 TURN STRUCTURE

SEVEN PHASES, EVERY TURN

1. REFRESH

Ready every Exhausted Personnel, Facility, and Equipment you control. This happens automatically — no player may respond to it.

2. BREACH

Check the current Breach Track band and resolve any “at your Breach Phase” abilities. If Breach is at 10, resolve a Catastrophic Breach right now (see The Breach Track).

3. DRAW

Draw one card.

4. MAIN

Play at sorcery speed: deploy up to one Facility, deploy any Personnel, Anomalies, or Equipment you can afford, and play Protocols or Directives.

5. COMBAT

Declare attackers, then your opponent declares blockers, then damage is dealt (see Combat).

6. SECOND MAIN

Identical rules to Main — anything left in hand you can still afford.

7. END

If you have more than 7 cards in hand, discard down to 7.

SORCERY SPEED VS. RESPONSE SPEED

Protocols and Directives can only be played during your own Main or Second Main phase, and only when nothing else is currently happening. Responses are the exception — true to their name, they can be played almost any time: during combat, during your opponent's turn, or reacting to another card as it happens.

A Personnel, Anomaly, or Facility can't attack or use an Exhaust-cost ability the turn it's deployed unless it has **Rapid Deployment** — it needs to have been under your control since the start of your most recent turn first.



06 COMBAT

ATTACKING & BLOCKING

- 1

Declare Attackers
You choose any number of your Ready Personnel/Anomalies that aren't affected by summoning restrictions and Exhaust them to attack. Attacks target your opponent by default.
- 2

Declare Blockers
Your opponent assigns any number of their Ready Personnel/Anomalies to block individual attackers. Blocking doesn't Exhaust the blocker. An attacker can be blocked by more than one card.
- 3

Damage
Each attacker and everything blocking it deal damage equal to their Power to each other, simultaneously. A card that's taken damage equal to or greater than its Durability this turn is destroyed and goes to its owner's discard pile.
- 4

Unblocked Damage
An attacker with no blockers deals its Power directly to the defending player's Stability.

OVERWHELM

If a card with Overwhelm is blocked, its controller assigns just enough damage to destroy the blocker(s) first, then sends any leftover damage through to the defending player's Stability.

RAPID DEPLOYMENT

Lets a card attack (or use an Exhaust-cost ability) the same turn it's deployed, skipping the usual wait.



07 THE BREACH TRACK

A CLOCK BOTH PLAYERS WIND

One shared 0-10 track. Both decks have ways to push it up or pull it back — what happens at each band changes who benefits from the current state of the board.



AT BREACH 10 — CATASTROPHIC BREACH
Each player loses 2 Stability. All Contained Anomalies are Released. Each player Exhausts one Ready Facility. Breach then resets to 5.

Several cards key their abilities directly to these bands. A **Danger**-labeled ability is live while Breach is 5 or higher; a **Critical**-labeled ability is live in the Critical band specifically (Breach 7-9); a **Catastrophe**-labeled ability triggers right after a Catastrophic Breach finishes resolving.

08

SUPPRESSION & CONTAINMENT

THE CORE LOOP

This is Containment's signature system — everything else in the game exists to push this cycle one way or the other.

DEPLOY
Ruin plays an Anomaly onto the battlefield. It attacks and blocks like any Personnel.

SUPPRESS
Authority applies Suppression counters to it. Once it has 1+, it's "Suppressed." Suppression counters stay on it until removed by name — they don't clear on their own.

CONTAIN
While Suppressed, Authority pays the Anomaly's printed Contain cost at a Containment Facility with open Capacity, moving it to the Contained zone under Authority's control.

RELEASE
A Release effect returns it to the battlefield as an active threat, under the control of whoever originally cast it — usually spiking Breach as the cost of letting it out.

RULE	DETAIL
Who can Suppress	Either player can target any Anomaly with a Suppress effect, but in practice it's almost always Authority weakening an opponent's Anomaly.
Containing requires	The Anomaly must be Suppressed, and you need a Containment Facility you control with Capacity still open. Pay the cost printed on the Anomaly (e.g. "Contain — 3") in Energy.
While Contained	The Anomaly isn't on the battlefield — it can't attack, block, or be targeted by battlefield-only effects. It counts against its Facility's Capacity.
Releasing	Returns the Anomaly to the battlefield under its original caster's control. Any "Released —" ability on the Anomaly triggers now, unless the Facility it was Contained at disables Released abilities (Standard Containment Cell C-14).
Guard	A card with Guard stops <i>opponents</i> from Releasing Contained Anomalies you control while it's Ready. It doesn't stop you from Releasing your own.



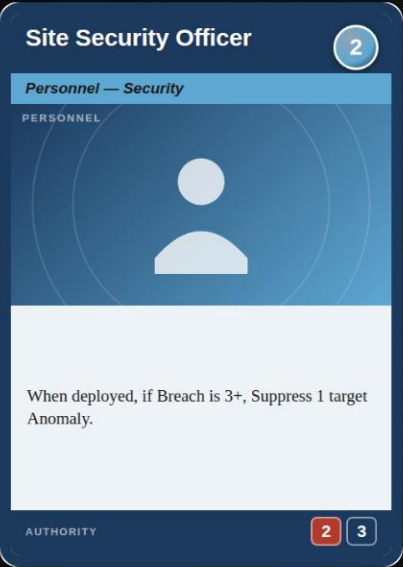
KEYWORDS & GLOSSARY

Every term below is grounded in how it's actually used across both starter decks. Suppress, Contain, and Release get their own dedicated section — this list gives the short version and cross-references it.

TERM	DEFINITION
Exhaust	Tap a card to pay an activated ability's cost, or force a target into that same tapped-down state so it can't act. Written both as a cost ("Exhaust: ...") and as an effect ("Exhaust target Anomaly").
Ready	The reverse of Exhaust — a card returns to an untapped, usable state and can attack, block, or activate again.
Suppress N / Suppressed	Apply N Suppression counters to an Anomaly. 1 or more counters makes it "Suppressed." See Suppression & Containment.
Contain / Contained	Move a Suppressed Anomaly into your control at a Containment Facility, paying its printed Contain cost. See Suppression & Containment.
Release / Released	Return a Contained Anomaly to the battlefield under its original caster's control. See Suppression & Containment.
Threat N	A fixed rating on Anomalies (2-5) used as a targeting restriction by other cards, e.g. "Exhaust target Anomaly with Threat 2 or less."
Capacity N	How many Anomalies a Containment Facility can hold Contained at once.
Stabilize N	Restore N Stability to yourself. Same effect as "restore N Stability" — different cards use either wording.
Sacrifice	Remove a card you control from play, usually as a cost, to trigger an effect.
Rapid Deployment	This card can attack, or use an Exhaust-cost ability, the turn it's deployed — it skips the usual one-turn wait.
Guard	While this card is Ready, Contained Anomalies you control can't be Released by an opponent's effects.
Overwhelm	If blocked, assign just enough damage to destroy the blocker(s), then send any leftover damage through to the defending player.
Clearance	A named status a specific card grants (currently only Black-Level Access Card) — its effect is written out on the card that grants it, not defined separately here.
Research	A persistent secondary resource. Unlike Energy, it never empties on its own.
Energy (typed)	The per-turn resource Facilities generate. Some is typed (Authority, Analysis, Ruin); spend typed Energy only on costs that accept that type or generic costs. Empties at your End Phase.
Danger / Critical	Ability headers keyed to the Breach Track: Danger is live at Breach 5+, Critical is live in the Critical band (Breach 7-9).
Catastrophe	An ability header that triggers right after a Catastrophic Breach (Breach hitting 10) finishes resolving.

10 CARD ANATOMY

READING A CARD



- 1 Name**
The card's unique title.
- 2 Cost**
Energy required to deploy or play it. Facilities show — (no cost).
- 3 Type line**
Category and subtype — e.g. Personnel — Security. "Unique" means only one copy of that exact card can be in play per player.
- 4 Category icon**
Quick visual read on card type: Personnel, Facility, Equipment, Protocol, or Anomaly.
- 5 Rules text**
What the card actually does, written in plain language plus keywords from the glossary.
- 6 Power / Durability**
Attack strength / damage it can take before being destroyed. Facilities and Protocols don't have this.

Anomaly cards additionally show a **Threat rating** in place of a subtype (e.g. "Anomaly — Threat 3") — the number other cards check when they target "Threat N or less."

11 FACTION DOSSIER

AUTHORITY

SECURE. CONTAIN. PRESERVE.

Control / midrange. Establish Personnel and Facilities, Suppress and Contain Anomalies, generate Research, and keep the shared Breach Track under control.

CATEGORY	COUNT
Personnel	20
Facilities	15
Equipment	7
Protocols	18
Total	60

SIGNATURE CARDS

DIRECTOR EVELYN VOSS
Anthem effect plus a card-draw
engine off Stabilizing.

**CHIEF CONTAINMENT OFFICER
HALE**
Guard locks down your Contained
Anomalies while Ready.

CONTAINMENT TEAM ALPHA-9
Big body that both Suppresses on
entry and rewards Containing.

SITE-WIDE LOCKDOWN
A board-wide reset button when Breach is spiraling.

12 FACTION DOSSIER

RUIN

RELEASE. EXPLOIT. TRANSCEND.

Aggressive risk/release. Sacrifice Personnel, escalate Breach, exploit Anomalies, sabotage containment, and turn Catastrophic Breaches into offensive windows.

CATEGORY	COUNT
Personnel	16
Anomalies	15
Facilities	13
Protocols	16
Total	60

SIGNATURE CARDS

THE UNNAMED WITNESS

A modal payoff that can Release, draw, or push Breach on entry.

SUBJECT ZERO

Locked behind Breach 7+, then punishes Authority for Containing anything.

THE THING BELOW

Gets cheaper as Breach climbs and comes back swinging after Catastrophe.

LET THEM OUT

Forces Catastrophic Breach on your terms, then rewards you for it.





QUICK REFERENCE

RULE	STANDARD
Deck size	60+ cards (starters are exactly 60); max 4 copies per name except Basic Facilities
Starting state	20 Stability · 7-card opening hand · Breach 0 · max hand size 7
Losing	Stability reaches 0 or below, or you must draw from an empty deck
Turn order	Refresh → Breach → Draw → Main → Combat → Second Main → End
Breach bands	0–2 Stable · 3–4 Unstable · 5–6 Danger · 7–9 Critical · 10 Catastrophic
Catastrophic Breach	Each player –2 Stability, Contained Anomalies Released, each Exhausts one Ready Facility, Breach resets to 5
Suppress → Contain → Release	Weaken an Anomaly, pay its Contain cost at an open Containment Facility, or let it back out later
Facility limit	One deployed per turn
Energy	Empties at your End Phase — Research does not
Competitive side deck	15 cards

This is a design prototype. Costs, wording, and quantities are subject to playtesting. See DECKLISTS.md for the full card-by-card lists.

